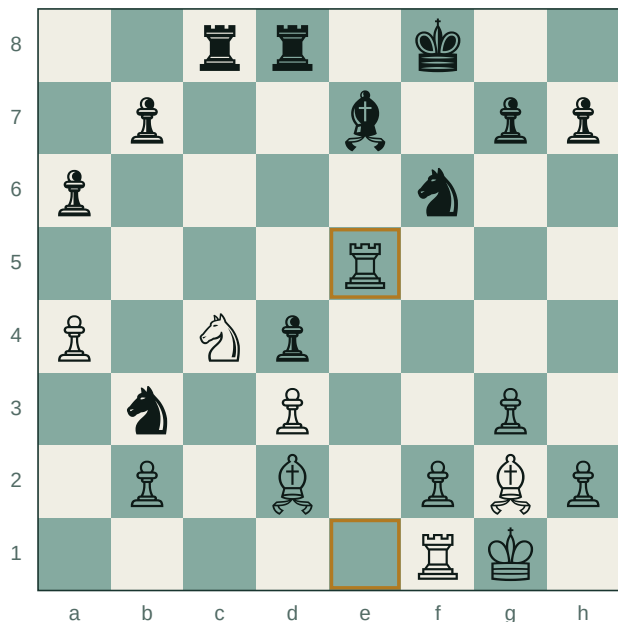


# Capture the defender: Black, move 23

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 23.Rxe5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

**WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST**

**23...Rxc4 24. dxc4 Nxd2**

**23...Rxc4** The rook captures the knight on c4. Recorded reply: **24.dxc4**.

**24...Nxd2** The knight captures the bishop on d2.

At the end, nominal material is White 19 / Black 19 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

**CHECKPOINT**

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1:** the balance goes from -1 to +0. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

**CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES**

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

**WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES**

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

**HOW TO LOOK**

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.